FOUNDERS LAB · COHORT 2

Base Grant Assessment: How Founders Are Selected

Information session for founders and hub partners

ELIGIBILITY WINDOW & OVERVIEW

Funding Objective

Support founders who have demonstrated commitment to the programme, validated market assumptions, built a testable MVP, and developed a clear plan for deploying capital towards venture growth.



Applications Open

Week 6
Oct 16, 2026



Applications Close

Week 7
Oct 25, 2026



Target Number of Grantees

Up to 50 per cohort

Four stages from eligibility to disbursement

Every application moves through the same four stages, in order



STAGE 1

Eligibility Gate

Reviewers
iDICE Programme Team

STAGE 2

Investment Team Scoring

Reviewers
Ventures Platform Investment Team

STAGE 3

Sign off

Reviewers
BOI Team

STAGE 4

Pre-Announcement & Disbursement

Reviewers
iDICE Programme Team

Quality control is applied across all four stages.

Stage 1: Eligibility screening

Based on programme discipline. All criteria must be MET to proceed to scoring

LIVE Session Attendance

Min 95% attendance at all LIVE (virtual and physical) sessions

LMS Completion

100% completion of modules as at review date.

Mentor Feedback Score & Assignment Completion

Assignments 1–5 submitted;
Mentor scoring on assignment quality

MVP Development

The participant has shared a link to their MVP or prototype, which may include a functional product, clickable prototype, demonstration video, screenshots, photographs, or other relevant evidence.

Stage 2: Four areas, scored out of 100

Funding assessment scoring by the Ventures Platform Investment Team

30 pts

Market Validation

Customer interviews, market demand, insights & iteration

25 pts

MVP Progress

Core user journey, functionality, user testing

20 pts

Innovation

Differentiation, technology application, scalability

25 pts

Use of Funds

Budget clarity, strategic alignment, feasibility

Market Validation 30 pts

Quality matters more than quantity. A high number of interviews, survey responses or sign-ups is not enough on its own; show what you have learned and what the evidence reveals about customer demand.

Indicator (scored 0-5)	Evidence examples	What strong evidence shows
Customer Interviews and Engagement	Records of customer interviews, survey responses, interview notes or other documented engagement with potential customers.	You have engaged potential customers to understand their needs and challenges, with clear findings, not just a count of interviews.
Evidence of Market Demand	Sign-ups, waitlists, letters of intent (LoIs), pilot users, survey results or paying customers.	Genuine customer interest or willingness to use or pay for your solution, backed by relevant, credible evidence.
Customer Insights and Iteration	Key findings from customer interviews, feedback summaries, changes to the business idea or MVP, or improvements made since programme enrolment.	Useful insights from your validation activities, and how customer feedback has refined your solution or business approach since enrolment.

MVP Progress 25 pts

Your MVP does not need to be a fully functional product. An early-stage prototype is acceptable; what matters is the strength and relevance of the evidence you submit.

Indicator (scored 0-5)	Evidence examples	What strong evidence shows
Completion of a core user journey or key functionality	Website or app link; Figma prototype; screenshots; demo video; photographs of a physical product; link to a no-code tool such as Glide, Bubble or Lovable.	You have built something that demonstrates your proposed solution, not only an idea or business plan.
Functionality and Problem Solving	A demo showing how it works, screenshots of key features or a simple example of how it solves the problem.	The main function of your solution and how it addresses the problem you identified. A fully developed product is not expected.
Evidence of initial user exposure or testing	Feedback from potential users, survey responses, screenshots of user interactions or records of product testing.	Your product has been in front of real users, with testing notes, screen recordings or feedback to show for it.

Innovation 20 pts

Scoring reflects your stage of development. The focus is on the quality of your idea and its potential; established market dominance or proven scalability is not expected.

Indicator (scored 0-5)	Evidence examples	What strong evidence shows
Differentiation & Value Proposition	Description of what makes the solution different from existing alternatives and the benefit it offers customers.	A clear benefit or meaningful improvement over existing alternatives.
Technology Application	Description or demonstration of how technology is used in the solution, such as an app, website, AI tool or digital platform.	Technology applied appropriately to solve the problem, not included for its own sake.
Scalability potential	Plans to reach more customers, expand geographically or serve additional market segments.	Potential to serve more customers or enter new markets as your business grows.

Use of Funds 25 pts

Show a realistic plan for using the grant to advance your business: relevant expenses, clear outcomes and a credible path to achieving them.

Indicator (scored 0-5)	Evidence examples	What strong evidence shows
Budget clarity and completeness	Itemised budget showing proposed expenses, quantities and estimated costs.	A budget that is clear, sufficiently detailed and easy to understand.
Strategic alignment with venture priorities	Proposed expenses such as MVP development, equipment, software, customer testing or product improvement.	Expenses that address your venture's key needs and priorities at its current stage.
Feasibility, milestones & expected outcomes	Planned activities, timelines and expected results, such as launching an MVP, testing with customers or acquiring initial users.	Realistic activities, with milestones and expected outcomes that are clear and achievable.

Stage 3: Shortlisting

How scored applicants are ranked and the final selection is balanced



Ranking

Rank every scored applicant by total score, highest first.



Inclusivity

Final selection should ensure a fair spread across all zones - at least 5 base grant winners per zone and female representation



Tie-break

Where totals are equal, the higher Innovation total ranks first, then the higher MVP Progress total.

About scores and results

Individual scores will not be shared

We understand that founders would like to see their scores. However, the total score is only one part of the selection decision.

Because final selection also takes other factors into account, a score on its own would not give a full or fair picture of why an application was or was not selected.

Final selection also considers

- Balance across zones
- Female representation
- Conduct

Every application is reviewed against the same criteria, with quality control applied at every stage.

Stage 4: Pre-announcement & disbursement

All shortlisted participants must have these three in place



Business registration

All shortlisted participants must have completed their business registration



Business bank account

All shortlisted participants must have a business bank account



Tax Identification Number (TIN)

All shortlisted participants must have a TIN

Start now: registration, bank account and TIN can take time to process.

Beyond the Base Grant: the Top-Up Grant

Top-Up Grant recipients will be selected from the Top 15 Base Grant recipients

50

Top 50

Base Grant recipients

15

Top 15

Shortlisted from the Base Grant recipients



Top-Up Grant

Recipients selected from the Top 15

Further details on the Top-Up Grant selection process will be shared with shortlisted founders.

What this means for founders and hubs

Founders

- Keep LIVE session attendance at 95% or above
- Complete 100% of LMS modules
- Submit Assignments 1–5
- Share a link to your MVP or prototype
- Document customer interviews and demand evidence
- Prepare an itemised budget with milestones
- Get registration, business bank account and TIN ready

Hubs

- Confirm attendance records for physical sessions
- Ensure mentors grade Assignments 1–5
- Support founders to test their MVP with real users
- Guide founders on credible evidence of market demand
- Follow up on registration, bank account and TIN readiness

TIMELINE & DISBURSEMENT

Week 6 - 7 Oct 16 - 25	Funding Applications Open
Weeks 8-9 Oct 26-Nov 6	Application Review, Assessment & Scoring
Week 10 Nov 9-13	Consolidated Ranking · Steering Committee Review · BOI Sign-off · Notifications to top 50 and 15
Week 11 Nov 16	Top 15 Ventures — Cohort Top-Up Grant: Pitch Deck Submission
Week 12 Nov 25	Top 15 Ventures — Cohort Top-Up Grant: Virtual Pitch Competition Cohort Close-Out Ceremony
Post-Programme December	Base & Top-Up Grant Disbursement

Base and Top-Up Grant funds will be disbursed at programme close following completion of all approval processes.



Questions?

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